



“There are a lot of people who say that bombing cannot win the war. My reply to that is that it has never been tried... and we shall see.”

AIR CHIEF MARSHAL
SIR ARTHUR HARRIS

HEAD OF RAF BOMBER COMMAND, 1942

DEATH FROM THE AIR

ALLIED BOMBING REDUCED ENEMY CITIES TO RUINS, BUT AT A COST THAT SHOCKED THOSE WHO BELIEVED THAT “THE BOMBER WOULD ALWAYS GET THROUGH”

THERE ARE FEW MORE apocalyptic images of total war than the mass bomber formations of World War II in action – at times more than a thousand aircraft filling the sky, some stretch of earth beneath them battered into an inferno of dust, smoke, and fire. Yet if the bomber raid offered a spectacle of power and impersonal destruction on a grand scale, the men who crewed the bombers were very far from invulnerable. For much of the war, Allied bomber crews had a higher chance of dying than the people they were bombing.

USAAF 15th Air Force bombardier Howard Jackson recalled his feelings before flying in a raid over Germany in World War II: “The terror starts on the night before the mission. This should not be confused with fear. Fear is when you have to ask a girl to dance who might say no... Terror is anxiety, dreams, rationalization of excuses not to fly, headaches, loose bowels, shaking and silence.” Such feelings were almost universal, and perfectly rational. No one in the American and British armed forces had a more dangerous job than bomber crews. The USAAF Eighth Air Force –

the “Mighty Eighth” – which carried out a daylight bombing offensive against Germany from 1942 to 1945, lost 26,000 men – one in eight of those who flew into action – as well as another 40,000 either wounded or shot down and made

prisoners of war. RAF Bomber Command lost a staggering 56,000 of its British and Commonwealth crew members – more than half of those who took part in its nighttime strategic

bombing campaign. At times the youthful bomber aircrews – typically men aged between 19 and 22 – faced a tour of duty with little more chance of survival than a World War I infantryman sent “over the top” at the Somme or Verdun. In late June 1943, the USAAF’s 381st Bomb Group entered combat with 36 crews, flying B-17s out of Ridgewell in eastern England. By the second week in October, only 10 of the original crews survived. In the winter of 1943–44, airmen flying for Bomber Command were estimated to have a one

in five chance of surviving a 30-mission tour of duty, and those were better odds than they had sometimes faced earlier in the war.

Strategic bombing

The bomber crews were asked to take this punishment because senior commanders believed that strategic bombing could make a vital contribution to winning the war, or even win it outright. Men such as Sir Arthur Harris, in charge of Bomber Command, and General Carl Spaatz of the USAAF were convinced that if they were only given the resources, they could end the war without the need for land battles that would cost hundreds of thousands of soldiers’ lives.

The RAF’s bombing campaign got off to a slow start. Before the war, RAF commanders had argued for the “deterrent” effect of a strategic bomber force – the threat of having his cities destroyed from the air would stay the aggressor’s hand. But when Hitler invaded Poland, no attempt was made to force a German withdrawal by bombing cities. Britain’s political leaders were anxious to avoid provoking German reprisals and eager to curry favor with President Roosevelt,



READY FOR ACTION

A Canadian crew stands ready for a mission in their Wellington bomber. Canadian airmen flew both for the RAF and in their own Royal Canadian Air Force squadrons.



JUNKERS NIGHT FIGHTER

Designed as a fast bomber, the versatile Junkers Ju 88 also gave excellent service as a night fighter defending Germany against Allied bombing raids. The aerials protruding from the nose are part of the Lichtenstein airborne radar system.